



SUNDAY MORNING · KITCHEN TABLE TRADITION

THE OFFICIAL FIREHALL RED LEAD RECIPE

The senior cook's cast-iron centerpiece — seared steak, peppers, potatoes, and eggs — for the spread that gathers the crew around the table.

Red Lead is not a grab-and-go breakfast. In halls that still run a proper Sunday morning, it sits at the center of a long, unhurried spread — bacon on sheet pans, toast stacked warm, beans simmering, coffee refilled, and firefighters drifting in from the bunk room one conversation at a time.

This card documents the skillet itself: one proud pan in a larger tradition. The meal matters, but the people around the kitchen table matter more. Print it, cook it on a morning when the tones are quiet, and leave room at the table for the crew to actually sit down together.

COOK TIME

About 40 min

BEST FOR

Sunday table spread

BEST PAN

12-inch cast iron



WHAT RED LEAD IS — AND WHY THE TABLE STILL MATTERS

Red Lead is hall language for the senior cook's showpiece skillet — the pan that lands on the kitchen table when breakfast is a crew event, not a pit stop. You will hear the name in stations across North America, often tied to the officer's red helmet tradition or simply to whoever is *leading* the line that morning. It is respect earned at the range, not a brand name printed on a box.

The tradition runs slow. Sunday after a busy night, or any morning when the hall is not chasing tones, the kitchen fills with the smell of bacon, coffee on its second pot, and cast iron that has been working long enough to build real color. People pull chairs up. Rookies learn how your hall takes eggs. Old hands tell the same stories. Nobody is watching the clock.

Red Lead is **one piece** of that spread — not the whole breakfast. The table still carries eggs done

your way, toast, baked beans, hash browns or home fries, bacon or peameal, sausage, orange juice, and sometimes a bowl of Greek yogurt with granola and berries for whoever wants something lighter. The skillet earns its place because it anchors the table; it does not replace everything else on it.

Firefighters remember these mornings for the room, not the recipe card. Steak strips and eggs from cast iron give the cook something to be proud of, but the crew gathers for the camaraderie — coffee poured twice, plates passed, ten extra minutes at the table before anyone checks their phone. **This Firehall Meals version** documents the skillet: seared protein, crisp potatoes, peppers, eggs cracked over the top — meant to be carried to a table already set for a proper hall breakfast.

The meal matters. The people around the table matter more. Cook your hall's full spread your way — use this card for the Red Lead pan itself: batch searing, par-cooked potatoes, egg wells, and a gentle covered finish so whites set without ruining the yolks someone will dip their toast into.

WHEN HALLS RUN IT

- Sunday morning, when the crew can eat together without rushing
- After a long night shift, when the kitchen table is the debrief
- Training weekends or family days, when visitors stay for coffee
- Any morning the officer says, "Sit down — we're doing breakfast properly"



INGREDIENTS

Read the full list before you touch a knife. This is the Red Lead pan only — the rest of the hall spread (bacon, beans, toast, extra eggs, juice) gets its own prep. Scale the skillet exactly; the senior cook's credibility is partly in not running out of the centerpiece.

SERVES 4

- 1 lb sirloin or flank steak, sliced thin against the grain
- 7 large eggs
- 2 bell peppers, mixed colors, sliced
- ½ medium red onion, sliced thin
- 1¾ lb Yukon gold potatoes, diced ½-inch
- 1½ tbsp steak seasoning (or equal parts salt, pepper, garlic powder)
- 1½ tbsp vegetable oil, plus butter for finishing
- ¾ cup shredded pepper jack (optional)
- Salt and black pepper to taste

SERVES 8

- 2 lb sirloin or flank steak, sliced thin against the grain
- 14 large eggs
- 3 bell peppers, mixed colors, sliced
- 1 medium red onion, sliced thin
- 3½ lb Yukon gold potatoes, diced ½-inch
- 3 tbsp steak seasoning (or equal parts salt, pepper, garlic powder)
- 3 tbsp vegetable oil, plus butter for finishing
- 1½ cups shredded pepper jack (optional)
- Salt and black pepper to taste

SERVES 12

- 3 lb sirloin or flank steak, sliced thin against the grain
- 21 large eggs
- 4–5 bell peppers, mixed colors, sliced
- 1½ medium red onions, sliced thin
- 5¼ lb Yukon gold potatoes, diced ½-inch
- 4½ tbsp steak seasoning (or equal parts salt, pepper, garlic powder)
- 4½ tbsp vegetable oil, plus butter for finishing
- 2¼ cups shredded pepper jack (optional)
- Salt and black pepper to taste

BEFORE YOU START — ROOKIE PREP CHECKLIST

TASK	WHY IT MATTERS
Slice steak thin, against the grain	Thick strips stay chewy; thin strips sear in minutes.
Dice potatoes uniform ½-inch	Even pieces par-cook and crisp at the same rate.
Pat steak and potatoes dry	Water kills sear color and steams instead of browning.
Preheat cast iron 5 minutes	Cold iron absorbs heat; steak grays instead of browning.
Have a lid or sheet pan ready	Egg finish needs covered steam — no lid means dry whites.

For 12 servings, use two 12-inch skillets or one large griddle plus a finishing pan. Do not crowd a single pan — batch the steak and potatoes, then combine for the egg stage.



STEP-BY-STEP — ASSUME YOU HAVE NEVER MADE IT

Follow the order. The pan has a rhythm: potatoes first, steak second, veg third, eggs last. Start the rest of the spread before the skillet — bacon in the oven, beans warming, toast ready — so when the eggs go on, the table is set and the crew can sit. If the tones drop, turn off heat, cover the pan, and pick up where you left off. A proper breakfast waits for the room, not the other way around.

1. STEP 1 · PAR-COOK THE POTATOES (ABOUT 8 MINUTES)

Place diced potatoes in a microwave-safe bowl with a splash of water. Cover and microwave until just tender when pierced with a fork — not mushy. Drain well, spread on a towel, and pat completely dry.

Visual cue: pieces bend slightly but still hold their shape. Wet potatoes steam in the skillet and never crisp.

Hold covered off heat up to 20 minutes if you need to pause.

2. STEP 2 · SEAR THE STEAK STRIPS (ABOUT 8 MINUTES)

Heat cast iron over **high** with oil until the oil shimmers and the pan surface reads about **400°F** (water droplets should skitter). Working in batches so the meat is not crowded, lay steak in a single layer. Sear **2–3 minutes per side** until deeply browned. Target **130°F internal** for medium-rare strips — they finish gently later. Transfer to a warm tray, loosely covered with foil.

Visual cue: dark crust on the edges, pink center when you cut a test piece. Gray, steaming meat means the pan was not hot enough.

3. STEP 3 · CRISP POTATOES AND PEPPERS (ABOUT 10 MINUTES)

Add another tablespoon of oil to the same pan. Add potatoes in one layer — do not stir for the first **3 minutes**. Let them sit so they pick up color. Toss, then add onion and peppers. Cook over **medium-high**, stirring occasionally, until edges char and onions turn translucent with golden spots.

Visual cue: potato faces show golden-brown patches; peppers blister at the edges.



4. STEP 4 · COMBINE AND MAKE EGG WELLS (ABOUT 3 MINUTES)

Fold seared steak and any resting juices back into the skillet. Lower heat to **medium**. With the back of a spoon, make shallow wells across the surface — one well per egg. Crack an egg into each well. Season with salt and pepper.

Visual cue: whites begin to turn opaque at the edges while yolks stay bright and domed.

5. STEP 5 · COVER AND FINISH (ABOUT 6 MINUTES)

Cover with a tight lid or inverted sheet pan. Cook over **medium-low** until egg whites are fully set — **165°F** on the white if you temp — and yolks are runny or jammy, your call. Scatter pepper jack if using, cover **60 seconds** to melt, then serve straight from the pan or onto warm plates.

Visual cue: whites opaque all the way through; yolk jiggles when you shake the pan gently. Green ring around the yolk means overcooked — next time lower heat and shorten the cover time.

ROOKIE TIPS — READ BEFORE YOUR FIRST SHIFT COOK

COMMON MISTAKES

- **Crowding the pan.** Steak steams; potatoes boil. Batch cook, then combine.
- **Skipping the potato par-cook.** Raw centers mean either burnt outsides or raw middles.
- **Cracking eggs onto a screaming-hot surface.** Whites seize and brown before they spread. Medium heat for the egg stage.
- **No cover on the eggs.** You get slick raw whites on top and dry bottoms underneath.

HOW TO AVOID BURNING IT

- Use medium-high for veg, not full blast — cast iron keeps getting hotter.
- Keep moving the pan off heat for 30 seconds if you smell acrid oil, then adjust.
- Finish eggs on medium-low. Patience beats a blackened bottom.

BEST TOMATOES (AND PEPPERS) FOR THE HALL

This skillet builds flavor from peppers and onion, not tomato sauce — but most halls still put something red on the table. For a side of pico or warmed salsa, use **Roma or vine-ripe tomatoes** with salt ten minutes before serving so they taste bright, not watery. Avoid pre-diced supermarket tubs — they weep and dilute everything. For the pan itself, pick peppers with tight skin; bell peppers should feel heavy and snap when you slice.

BEST SIDE DISHES ON THE SAME SPREAD

The skillet is the centerpiece — not the whole table. Most halls still set out baked beans, extra eggs (scrambled or fried to order), toast, hash browns or home fries if the pan potatoes are not enough, bacon or peameal bacon, link sausage, orange juice, and sometimes Greek yogurt with granola, strawberries,

and blueberries for crew who want something lighter. Let people build their own plate and stay at the table.



THE FULL SUNDAY KITCHEN TABLE

Red Lead belongs in the middle of a traditional firehall breakfast — one proud pan among many bowls and platters. The senior runs cast iron; everyone else keeps the table alive with sides, coffee, and conversation. Nobody should be standing alone at the range while the crew eats without them.

EGGS

The skillet carries cracked eggs in the pan — that is the Red Lead showpiece. Still put extra eggs on the table: scrambled in a hotel pan, fried to order on a flat griddle, or soft-boiled for crew who want them separate. Second helpings happen; plan for it.

BACON & PEAMEAL

Lay bacon on rimmed sheet pans and bake at **400°F for 15–18 minutes** until crisp. Peameal slices get the same treatment or a light sear on the griddle. Stack on paper towels, hold warm, refill the platter when the first batch disappears — which it will.

SAUSAGE

Link sausage in the oven alongside the bacon, or bulk sausage broken into crumbles in a second pan. Keep it simple — salt and pepper. Serve in a warm bowl at the table with tongs; let people take what they want while the coffee pot makes another round.

TOAST

Thick bread through the toaster or under **low broil, 2–3 minutes per side**. Stack loosely in foil in a warm oven. Butter and jam on the table — not pre-buttered stacks that sit and sweat while the crew is still talking.

BEANS

Baked beans warmed in a pot or slow oven — the quiet side that anchors a Canadian hall breakfast. A can simmered with a spoon of mustard and molasses is honest work. Keep a ladle on the table next to the toast.

POTATOES & HASH BROWNS

The skillet already carries diced Yukon golds. If your hall always sets out hash browns or extra home fries, run them on a flat griddle while the Red Lead finishes under cover — keep them separate so neither pan fights for temperature.

ORANGE JUICE

Pitcher on the table, refilled once without being asked. It sounds small; it is not. The crew notices when the little things are handled before anyone has to ask.

GREEK YOGURT (OPTIONAL)

Some halls put out Greek yogurt with granola, strawberries, and blueberries — for crew who want something lighter or who eat around the heavy plate and still stay at the table for the conversation.

COFFEE & THE TABLE

Start the first pot before the steak hits the pan. When the eggs go under cover, call the crew to the table — not to a line, to *chairs*. The skillet comes last, placed in the middle where everyone can reach it. That is the tradition.

Station workflow: One cook on the Red Lead pan, others on bacon, beans, toast, and coffee. The goal is a full table and an empty bunk room — firefighters sitting together long enough to remember why they like this job.



FIREHALL MEALS

KEEP THE TRADITION AT YOUR TABLE

You just read the recipe for one pan in a morning that is really about the room — chairs pulled up, coffee going cold while nobody notices, stories that do not need a punchline. Keep this card in the kitchen for the technique. Keep the table set for the crew.

When it is not a Sunday and the hall needs dinner instead of breakfast, Firehall Meals carries **250+ firehall-tested recipes** sized for real crews — the same respect for portions, timing, and station kitchens, written by firefighters who know what interruption feels like at the range.

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